

Constructive Feedback & Correction Guide

How to support your partner's linguistic growth, correct speech habits, and align call dynamics with empathy and clarity.

Learning a new language is an inherently vulnerable process that requires a safe space to make mistakes. Repetitive mistakes or speech habits are part of this journey and, if left unaddressed, can become ingrained. In **Language Exchange**, knowing how and when to give feedback transforms mistakes into real development opportunities, both in language skills and in the harmony of your partnership.

1. The Behavioral and Structural Feedback Model (3 Steps)

To align program dynamics, suggest improvements to session flow, or address potential discomforts (such as one person speaking much more than the other), we use an objective and empathetic structure based on facts and impacts:

Step 1

WHAT HAPPENED

Present the concrete fact neutrally, without value judgments or generalizations.

Step 2

THE IMPACT / FEELING

Explain the direct consequence of this fact on the call or how the situation made you feel.

Step 3

NEXT TIMES

Propose an alignment or a clear, objective action for subsequent meetings.



Practical Application Example (Time Balance):

"In our last call, we ended up talking for almost 35 minutes in English and had very little time left for Spanish (what happened). Because of that, I felt like I couldn't practice the goals I had set for the week (the consequences/how I felt). Next time, what do you think if we set an alarm on our phones at the 20-minute mark to remind us to switch languages? (what to do next time)."

2. Immediate Feedback Methods for Linguistic Errors

Interrupting someone at every grammatical error breaks their train of thought and erodes the speaker's confidence. For linguistic, contextual, or pronunciation corrections during dialogue flow, we recommend agile and welcoming methods:

A. Corrective Mirroring Technique (Recast)

The most fluid and least intrusive method. Repeat the phrase the partner said incorrectly, but in a corrected and natural way, continuing the conversation without pointing fingers at the error.

Partner: "Yesterday I go to the supermarket and bought some fruits."

You (Mirroring): "Ah, nice! You went to the supermarket! What kind of fruits did you buy?"

B. Confirmation Echo Technique

Great for pronunciation errors or vocabulary inappropriate to the context. Repeat the word with the correct intonation in a questioning tone, simulating that you are just confirming the information.

Partner: "I really love to eat cho-co-la-te (pronounced in a Portuguese way)."

You (Echo): "Chocolate? (native pronunciation). Me too! Dark chocolate is my favorite."

C. Dynamic Notepad Method (Delayed Annotation)

For repetitive speech habits (e.g., saying "depend on" instead of "dépend de" in French, or constantly making pronoun errors), let the person finish their idea, note down key points, and wrap up in the last 5 minutes of the call.

How to approach: "Your explanation of that movie was great! I just noticed a small habit that repeated a few times, which was using word X instead of Y. Shall we practice that phrase real quick before we finish?"

3. Best Practices for Creating a Comfortable Environment

- **Prior Alignment Agreement:** Right in your first meeting as a pair, ask about the other person's preference: *"Do you prefer that I interrupt to correct you on the spot, or should I take notes so we can discuss at the end of the session?"*.
- **Value Progress:** Always balance a correction with positive reinforcement about your partner's progress in pronunciation, vocabulary, or clarity of thought.

Making mistakes is part of achieving fluency. Use these tools in **Language Exchange** to grow together with your partner!